

Being an Ally at Work

From intention to action

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

From intention to action

You want to be an ally to racialized and underrepresented people at work, but you don't always know how — afraid of getting it wrong, or not seeing what's at play. Allyship isn't a stance: it's a practice, and it can be learned.

This guide helps you understand your own reflexes, move past guilt or defensiveness, and take concrete, useful acts of allyship.

Your intention

A situation where you'd like to be a better ally: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Your own lens

We all grew up in an environment that shaped how we see — with blind spots. Being an ally starts with honestly looking at your own reflexes and conditioning, without guilt, but without denial.

Recognizing your blind spots isn't accusing yourself: it's the condition for seeing better.

Example

Sure he was 'neutral', Marc realized he interrupted certain colleagues more often. Seeing it let him change.

Exercise — My blind spots

Write: in which moments might I fail to see what my underrepresented colleagues experience?

My starting point

What don't I know / haven't I lived, that I'd gain from listening to?

→ *Seeing my blind spots is the start of allyship — not a fault.*

Moving past defensiveness

When the topic comes up, defensive thoughts arise: 'I'm not racist, so it doesn't concern me', 'that's exaggerated', 'I might say it wrong, so I'll stay quiet'. They protect the ego but block action.

Discomfort isn't a danger signal: it's often the sign that you're learning.

Example

Rather than justifying herself when a colleague flagged a discomfort, Inès listened. The relationship grew stronger.

Defensiveness journal

When you feel defensive, note: the thought · what the discomfort might teach me.

Reframe

Turn 'I might get it wrong so I do nothing' into 'I can learn by doing, and repair if needed'.

→ *Discomfort is information, not a threat. I can listen without defending.*

From guilt to responsibility

Guilt revolves around the self and paralyzes. Responsibility looks outward and acts. Being an ally means moving from 'I feel bad' to 'what can I usefully do?'.

You don't have to be perfect — just committed, over time.

Example

Instead of apologizing at length, Tom asked: 'how can I help concretely?' — and acted.

Exercise — From guilt to act

Note a situation where you felt guilty. What useful action could you have taken?

My lasting commitment

Write 1 ally commitment that's sustainable over time (not a one-off).

→ *Guilt paralyzes; responsibility acts.*

Concrete acts of allyship

Allyship is measured in acts, not intentions: amplify underrepresented voices, credit ideas, intervene on microaggressions, share power (mentoring, sponsoring, hiring), and do the work yourself instead of outsourcing it to those affected.

Support, without taking the place.

Example

In a meeting, Sofia repeated a colleague's idea while crediting her ('as X said...'). The idea was finally heard.

Exercise — My ally toolbox

Note: 1 way to amplify a voice · 1 way to intervene on a microaggression · 1 way to share power.

My first act

Pick ONE concrete ally act to take this week.

→ *Amplify, credit, intervene, share: acts, not intentions.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Amplify: repeat a colleague's idea while crediting them.
- Intervene: facing a microaggression, name it calmly ('that's not okay').
- Share power: mentor, sponsor, recommend underrepresented people.
- Listen without defending: if someone flags an impact, take it in, don't justify.
- Do the work yourself: get informed, don't ask those affected to educate you.
- Commit over time: allyship is a practice, not a one-off.

To fill in

Ally journal

Date	The situation	My reaction	A possible ally act

My toolbox

Amplify	Intervene	Share power

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — See my blind spots.

Week 2 — Move past defensiveness.

Week 3 — From guilt to action.

Week 4 — Take acts of allyship.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The blind spot I watch:
- The defensive thought I reframe:
- My first ally act:

TO CLOSE

Allyship is acts — repeated, over time.

From intention to action, with humility.

*This guide is a reflection and coaching tool for becoming a better ally — not a certified training or legal advice. ©
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